

**Regular Meeting
Monday, May 20, 2019
Medford School Committee
Council Chambers**

Present: Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. Mustone, Mr. Ruggiero, Mr. Ruseau, Ms. Van der Kloot, Mayor Burke, Superintendent Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent, Associate Superintendent Diane Caldwell, Assistant Superintendent Kirsteen Patterson.

Roll Call and Salute the Flag - Meeting called to order at 7:03PM.

Approval of Minutes of May 20, 2019 - Ms. DiBenedetto requested that the request for cost of dyslexia consultants be added to requested reports. Motion to approve as amended offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Kreatz, motion granted.

Approval of Bills/Transfer of Funds and Approval of Payrolls - Ms. DiBenedetto asked about a line item about Boston University and special education. Motion to approve offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto. Roll call vote.

7 affirmative

0 negative

Motion passes.

Community Participation:

Jennifer Sawin - Styrofoam Trays - They are damaging to the environment. We should phase out the use of styrofoam trays. Zane Sawin - Kids put their food on styrofoam trays in the cafeteria. It goes into landfills and spills into the sea. I ask you to make a change and phase out styrofoam trays. Ms. Van der Kloot - Thank you for speaking up on this issue. Motion to send this to committee and do a study on the use of styrofoam trays and all single-use plastics in school cafeterias to report back by the end of the year offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto.

Roll call vote.

7 affirmative

0 negative

Motion passes.

Ms. Mustone motioned to suspend the rules to take an item out of order, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Recognition of Medford Middle School String Ensemble - Anthony Szykniej - This is a prestigious award, congratulations to the students and Ms. Sophia Chang. The students played a beautiful song. Ms. Van der Kloot - Thank you very much. Ms. DiBenedetto - Thank you to Ms. Chang and Mr. Szykniej. Dr. Edouard-Vincent - As a lover of the arts, I have been lucky to see concerts at the McGlynn and Andrews last week, thank you to all students, teachers, and a special thanks to the parents for supporting your children.

The students were given certificates of achievement.

Ms. Chang - Thank you to the administrators, students, and parents.

Motion to revert to regular order of business offered by Ms. Mustone, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, motion passes.

Sharon Hayes - ELA MCAS - I am re-asking questions about the 2018 MCAS results. My concerns are that the scores on the ELA test were disappointing. The analysis focused on average scores of the district, not the differences between schools. Demographic differences were not addressed. How are the differences in demographics among the elementary schools being addressed? Have any changes been considered to even the disparate scores across the elementary schools? Has Medford adopted any specific writing programs? Dr. Edouard-Vincent - There are differences in outcomes between the Brooks School and other schools. There are demographic differences, but there are a lot of factors that we take into consideration. You mentioned staffing. Some schools have higher instances of students with greater needs and teachers need to make accommodations. We can not compare every school because they are not the same. I look at how we are doing with student growth across the district and how we are making gains. At the Columbus, in ELA MCAS data, they exceeded their target. Each school is given their own target, so that we are not comparing schools to each other but to their own past performance. Just because you are not seeing identical outcomes does not mean you are seeing a difference in instruction. Different schools have different demographics which contribute to different scores. It should not be a judgment of one school over another. We cannot rest on one assessment. We are committed to moving the needle, but we should not compare schools to each other because it is not apples to apples. Ms. Hayes - I do not intend to pit schools against each other or to accuse teaching staff of not achieving, it is about the demographics. Dr. Edouard-Vincent - We are working collaboratively to address those issues, but we have neighborhood schools at the elementary level. We look to support the schools with higher needs. Ms. DiBenedetto - We have adopted a new science curriculum and expect to see results in the next few years. It takes a few years to see progress in scores. Thank you for coming forward and advocating for students.

Charlene Douglas and Members of the Medford Teachers Association -

Mr. Ruseau read his letter of apology to the teachers of Medford for inaccurate and offensive comments made at the May 6, 2019 School Committee meeting.

Ms. Douglas - We accept your apology. We would like to inform the School Committee of what our reading programs look like at the elementary level.

Ms. Douglas distributed information about phonics. Ms. Douglas - If teachers were not teaching phonics they would be given 30 days to improve and then they would be removed. We are teaching phonics.

Jane Mattuchio, first grade teacher at the Brooks Elementary - We teach letter sounds, we follow the curriculum. Even at the end of the year when we are playing games we are doing letter sounds every day.

Theresa Castagnetti - 23 Cushing Street, Medford - EL teacher - Thank you for giving us this time to speak this evening. I accept Mr. Ruseau's apology to the teachers. Portraying teachers in a negative light has a negative impact on the community. I love teaching in Medford, I love my colleagues, I can not bring myself to retire. I am not unique. Teachers give of themselves here. We have very dedicated teachers. Our teachers win awards. So yes we are incredible, talented, and caring professionals. I thank you for acknowledging that. We do teach phonics. Thank you to Mr. Ruseau and to the School Committee.

Meredith Mason-Crowley - I am a special education teacher at the McGlynn Middle School, teaching phonics has been my life's work. I have attended professional development and paid for it myself. We have a need for further professional development. When I requested funding to attend a dyslexia conference in 2017 I was unable to. Mr. Ruseau, phonics has been here in Medford but we have to do more and it has to come from the top down. I hope you use your frustration to help make a change. The students struggling right now should be prioritized in the budget.

Julieann Anderson - 220 Third Street, Medford - McGlynn Elementary - I work with students providing specialized reading instruction to students in elementary school. I attended trainings which I paid for myself. Will the School Committee provide funding to support full time paraprofessionals as needed to support our high needs students? We need to educate parents and provide them with the tools necessary to support their children at home. As a teacher we do not get to pick and choose what we teach. We follow guidelines from the district and the state. Our reading curriculum, Journeys, has phonics embedded within it. Please come to room 245 at

McGlynn Elementary and observe me teaching phonics in the classroom. Thank you for your time and I appreciate this opportunity.

Ms. Douglas - We are asking the School Committee to advocate for meaningful, fully-funded professional development. We have nothing to work with. Please attend our meeting in the high school library this Thursday. The only time I have seen any of you is at social events. In 32 years no member of the school committee ever came to my classroom. Call my cell phone 781-771-1098.

Ms. Caldwell - From an administrative point of view, we too were surprised by Mr. Ruseau's words. He has apologized. We want teachers to know that we support you, we try to listen to your needs, and we want to work with you on a regular basis. Teachers work tirelessly. Our teachers make Medford great.

Ms. Douglas - It is important for teachers to feel that they are appreciated and they make a difference. Morale is important. Our teachers deserve respect.

Dr. Ricciardelli - There is a tuition reimbursement program for professional development. Charlene Douglas and I go through the amounts together. It is based on the contract. When someone does not get approved for tuition reimbursement, it is because the course does not qualify and/or because it is first come, first serve. If they are rejected it is because the funding is exhausted. It is a maximum of \$1,000 per year per teacher.

Motion to see a physical report on the topic of teacher professional development offered by Mr. Ruggiero, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto, motion passes.

Ms. Douglas - Teachers are speaking about conferences. We put in to take a day. We get rejected and take a personal day.

Elisabetta Daneu- I was rejected from attending an AP conference because my principal said they could not afford to have me out of the building for three days in June. Mr. Ruggiero - I would like to know our policy on this.

Ms. Kreatz - Are there grants to support additional professional development?

Motion for suspension of the rules to move Medford PTO/PTG Annual Update out of order offered by Ms. Kreatz, seconded by Mr. Ruggiero, motion passes.

Medford PTO/PTG Annual Update - Jenny Graham and Kristy Avino - The city-wide group presented a PowerPoint presentation on the fundraising activities of the group. Ms. Graham - There is only one part-time librarian for all four elementary schools. Library curriculum is lacking and budget is lacking for the libraries. Cristina McGorty and Ingrid Moncada, representatives from the Columbus Elementary School PTO, presented a PowerPoint presentation on their spending activities over the course of the 2018-2019 school year. Bailey Schendell, McGlynn Elementary PTG President - The McGlynn Elementary went through a year of transition. A PowerPoint presentation was delivered outlining the fundraising and spending activities of the McGlynn PTG. The cost of buses has increased significantly and service is unreliable. What can we do about the monopoly Eastern Bus has on our field trip travel? Melissa Maywalt and Melissa DeMeo from the Roberts Elementary PTO - The representatives detailed their organization's 2018-2019 fundraising and spending in a PowerPoint presentation. We bought rugs this year. We hosted free activities so all students could be included. It is important that the district have equity with regard to technology across the elementary schools.

Ms. Van der Kloot - Thank you to the volunteers for coming and for raising money for the schools. Field trips are part of our negotiations with the bus companies which we do every three years. We will look at that when we next discuss contracts with the bus companies. I am concerned that the citywide alliance only includes the elementary schools. I would prefer to see it grow to the middle and high schools. Ms. Kreatz - Thank you to all for all you do and for the presentation. Ms. DiBenedetto - Thank you for waiting so long. Thank you for raising money for the children. We should move forward with resurfacing all the playgrounds. I want to make sure all the PTO/PTGs are 501(c)3s, including the citywide alliance. Ms. Graham - We are not there yet as a citywide alliance, but we have been discussing it. The two middle school PTOs have not reached out to ask to join the citywide alliance. We want to think carefully about the different dynamics of fundraising for elementary schools versus middle schools. We are totally open to collaborating with the middle schools on the Wizards game next year. Susan Powers - 1956 Highland Avenue - Andrews Middle School PTO - People are very open to combining efforts. As middle school parents we lack the engagement that some elementary school parents have. One of the things at the Andrews we have been able to do is buy 25 Chromebooks with a charging cart. We have talked about how to get more engaged, how to raise more funds, we would be happy to work together. We raised money for scholarships for the New York trip and there is a discrepancy between the middle schools where you can not necessarily raise funds the same way because we are a socioeconomically diverse city. Melanie McLaughlin - Austin Street - Thank you to the PTOs for raising funds for our district. On behalf of the special education parent advisory committee, we would be happy to be involved in this as well. One of the PTOs mentioned accessibility on the buses and that is our role and we would like to be included. Mr. Ruggiero - Thank you.

Recommendation to Approve Joan Bowen to Director of Pupil Services Position - Dr. Edouard-Vincent - I look forward to having Joan join the team. Motion to approve offered by Ms. Mustone, seconded by Ms. Kreatz,

Roll call vote:

7 Affirmative

0 Negative

Motion passes.

Recommendation to Approve Donation for the Jae S. Lim Science and Mathematics Prize - Diane Caldwell. Motion to approve offered by Ms. Mustone, seconded by Ms. Kreatz.

Roll call vote:

7 Affirmative

0 Negative

Motion passes.

Report on Project Bread - Sarah Cluggish, Rosemarie Caward, and Holly Grace - Our goal is to increase school breakfast and summer lunch participation. Provision 2 would allow the district to serve universal free breakfast. Schools will continue to receive federal reimbursements at a free and reduced basis but they will not receive parent contributions. We estimate that schools could double participation in school breakfast. Columbus has universal free breakfast and has 93% participation. If Provision 2 was implemented it could increase revenue for the schools. Kirsteen Patterson - Project Bread is a partner on many projects with us. As a proponent for school nutrition, I am an advocate for breakfast in the classroom. This is a snapshot of one month. The school lunch program is self-funded. We would need to do a full scale review of the feasibility of some of these initiatives. This one would be beneficial, but we are under some additional state mandates we would need to review. We have a lot of things to consider about the potential for school breakfast options. To address all of the needs we need a full year's review for the potential for reimbursement and funding. Mayor Burke - What are next steps for your department? Ms. Patterson - We would need to look at each school building and its ability to provide breakfast on a large scale with staffing. We need to look at all the information we would get for a full year, rather than one October's snapshot.

Mr. Ruseau - Motion to implement Provision 2, seconded by Ms. Mustone. Motion withdrawn.

Dr. Edouard-Vincent - This is not how we should make this decision. We have not done enough research. Ms. DiBenedetto - Can we answer some of the questions for implementation for next year? If we are not collecting data for students about whether they qualify for free or reduced lunch how do we calculate that low income students qualify for other benefits? Ms. Patterson - We are in motion to do some of this work. We are working with agencies to look at feasibility to

provide a confirmation of what the actual numbers would look like. We do lose some structure related to free and reduced accounts. If we offer free breakfast there may be an assumption that lunch is automatic. Ms. DiBenedetto - Can you provide the information for next meeting? Ms. Patterson - No. The last committee meeting in June is the 17th, that would be significantly difficult to accomplish. I can make every effort to compile that information. Mayor Burke - Food insecurity is a major issue in the city. However, we should have respect for the office that we may not have time to turn this around. Ms. Van der Kloot - Members are making themselves clear. We are in favor of providing our students with free breakfast. I am reluctant to vote on it without having a vote back from the administration.

Ms. Cluggish - There are many different models to consider. The district would need state approval to implement this. It would take a year. You do not have to implement this immediately. This is the first few steps to consider what is right for Medford and right for all the schools.

Motion to receive a report on feasibility of universal free breakfast district wide to be presented on June 17th offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot, motion passes.

Report on Massachusetts General Hospital Research Initiative to Understand and Reduce Cannabis Use in Adolescents - Dr. Randi Schuster - Marijuana is dangerous, which we all know. It could become a major issue soon. The study I am proposing would aim to understand whether abstaining from marijuana use for one to six months is associated with an improvement in cognitive performance among middle through high school age adolescents. Dr. Schuster summarized the study design. Ms. DiBenedetto - I would like full active consent for all parties. Dr. Schuster - We make sure we have consent. Mr. Ruggiero - Can you change your study to include a question about screen time? Dr. Schuster - We cast a narrow net but we can ask additional questions. Dr. Edouard-Vincent will present a recommendation to approve the study or not at the June 17th meeting. Motion to accept report and place on file offered by Ms. Kreatz, seconded by Ms. DiBenedetto, motion passes.

Recommendation to Approve Illustrative Math Curriculum Professional Development - Faiza Khan - Dr. Edouard-Vincent - This curriculum is generally accepted to be very strong for math instruction. We need to approve it to pay for professional development that begins next month. We were previously lacking a coherent math curriculum at the middle school level. Ms. Kreatz - I am concerned about there being no books and what if a student does not have a printer. Ms. Irving - McGlynn Middle School math teacher - EL students will have difficulty with this program because there is no book. The reason we do not have a unified program is a lack of professional development. Many of my students do not have a computer at home so they may not be able to access the materials. Ms. Khan - All student material, teacher material, and family

material are available online. We would have a classroom set. Teachers should be sending paper copies of the material home. I have talked to surrounding districts who have adopted it. Somerville and Arlington said that with PD they make photocopies and send them home. There is the problem with students losing photocopies. I see it as a co-problem of executive function and organizational skills. The organization has sent out surveys about problems teachers may anticipate and they build their professional development around those concerns. If we go with the company that has been recommended to us, we will be supported. There are aches and pains with any program but this is the program to go with. This is the way to move forward and I do not want our students to fall behind. I am confident in the capabilities of our teachers to rise to the occasion. Ms. Irving - I could not print the worksheets from school. Mayor Burke - Some students do not have access to computers at home. Ms. Khan - You have to be vigilant about which browser you are using. Ms. DiBenedetto - Have we piloted this program? Ms. Khan - Yes, two teachers have piloted the program. They both like it. They have some issues getting used to printing and geometry. There are always bumps in the road. Ms. DiBenedetto - I am concerned about the potential bumps in the road. Dr. Edouard-Vincent - There is no consistent curriculum for math in the middle schools. We need something so we know what to measure our performance against.

Motion to approve Illustrative Math offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Kreatz.

Roll call vote

6 Affirmative

1 Negative - Ms. DiBenedetto

Motion passes.

Condolences: Salvatore Caraviello, Elizabeth Irving, and Robert Irving.

A School Committee Resolution to hold harmless 2019 10th Grade MCAS due to racist question.

Motion to approve offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Mr. Ruggiero

Roll call vote

5 Affirmative

2 Absent - Ms. DiBenedetto, Ms. Kreatz

Motion passes.

Motion to table Report on K-12 Assessments offered by Mr. Ruseau, seconded by Ms. Mustone, motion passes.

Motion to table Superintendent's Updates and Comments offered by Ms. Van der Kloot, seconded by Mr. Ruseau, motion passes

Motion to adjourn at 11:20pm.